

MAY 2024

DIGITAL MEDIA STRATEGIES

PERSONAL RESEARCH DOSSIER

YANCHENG (ERIC) ZHANG, 48279374
CONVENOR: DR. CHRIS MULLER



POWERHOUSE



MACQUARIE
University

TABLE OF CONTENTS

3	INTRODUCTION
4	PART I. STRATEGY DEVELOPMENT
	ACTIVITIES AND VALIDATION INDUSTRY PRACTICES AND MEDIA STRATEGY OVERVIEW
6	PART II. INSPIRATIONS
	INITIAL BIG IDEA: #UNWRAPIT INSPIRATION OF #ORDINARYMASTERCLASS FURTHER EXPLORATION
8	PART III. TEAMWORK AND MYSELF
	TEAMWORK PRODUCTIVITY IMPROVEMENT SELF-ANALYSIS AND FUTURE PROJECTS
9	APPENDIXES
	A. MY PROJECT MOODBOARD B. DIGITAL PERSONAL PROJECT DOSSER
11	REFERENCES

Cover photo: Detroit Electric car, made by Anderson Electric Car Co, USA, 1917. Powerhouse Collection. Object No. B1057-1.
Photo by Hamish McIntosh

This dossier is only for educational use. Logos of Powerhouse Museum, Macquarie University, MOD., Notion, and images used in this dossier are the property of their respective copyright holders.

INTRODUCTION

Before encountering the 'Smartflush' sectioned toilet suite in the Powerhouse Collection, I never imagined seeing such 'strange' items in a museum except for Duchamp's 'Fountain'. This collection became an important source of inspiration for our project—everyday items that are rare to see in the museum are incredibly intriguing, and deconstructed objects are equally interesting. This exhibit, along side the Nokia 5185i, sparked various significant ideas throughout my strategy development journey, shaping different key aspects at each stage.

Figure 1. Mockup marketing poster for the potential project theme. Edited by Eric.



PART I. STRATEGY DEVELOPMENT

How did I go about developing my strategy?

In our initial group discussion, we started by reflecting on our own experiences as master students to identify our priorities when visiting museums or discussing museum research. Despite the diverse reasons for our interest in museums, we shared a common strategic goal—to engage with museums through new and unique experiences.

ACTIVITIES AND VALIDATION

Building upon this goal, I came up with some ideas for activities after the tour of Powerhouse. When Dr. Muller explained the story behind a Nokia phone and how it resonated with the student (see **Figure 2**), I was surprised that Powerhouse would collect mobile phones and delighted by the intersection of the functionality of everyday items and the emotional connections individuals have with them. This experience sparked the idea that our project could help everyone discover the storytelling value behind exhibits.

To further validate the feasibility and expandability of this idea, I developed it within my own workflow after our discussions. In the initial research phase, I focused on the segmentation of master students, reviewing industry reports and academic literature to extract insights that could potentially benefit our project. These insights were categorized into two main areas—their information input preferences and purposes in museum visits. Notably, a study by MOD. (2017, see **Figure 3**) indicated that master students' preference for museums using new technology also highlighted the need for old exhibits to be presented differently. This supported our goal and provided possible directions for activities.

After a few weeks of winding discussions (see **Figure 4** below), I proposed to the group that we could design activities to help everyone discover the storytelling value behind daily items and reinforce the impression of the extraordinary stories behind the ordinary objects in the Powerhouse collections. The masterclasses will include hands-on workshops where participants explore the 3D modeling (see **Figure 5** left) of everyday items, guided tours of relevant exhibits with storytelling technique instructions, and interactive discussions on curatorial practices.



Figure 2. During the tour, everyone in the room didn't expect there was a deep connection between Khandmaa's parents and the Nokia 5185i, which served a love bridge for them.

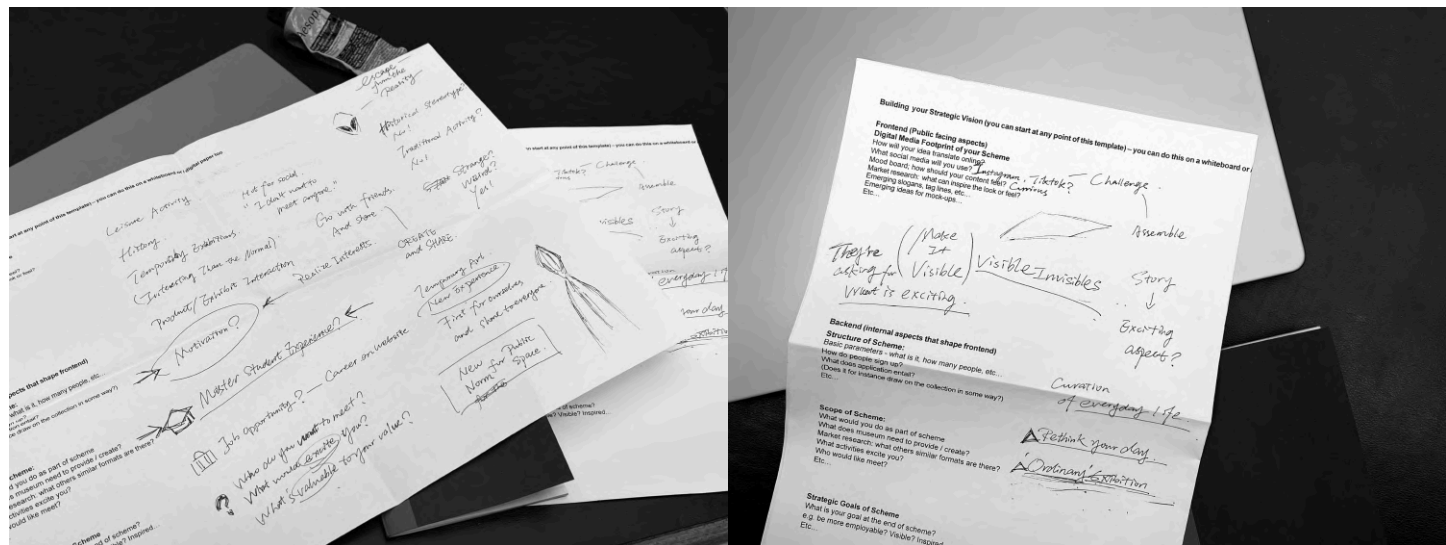
MOD.

Figure 3. MOD. is a futuristic museum of discovery, one of Australia's leading future-focused museums at University of South Australia.



Figure 5. The 3D modeling technology shown in the briefing with Dr Deborah Lawler Dormer.

Figure 4. Various wild ideas and thoughts and discussion mindmaps.



INDUSTRY PRACTICES AND MEDIA STRATEGY OVERVIEW

In terms of image establishment, just as the Victoria and Albert Museum (V&A) enhances its artistic and creative image through the London Design Festival, Powerhouse can strengthen its image in research and education through this series of masterclasses (V&A South Kensington, n.d.). By emphasizing the contrast between 'masterclass' and 'ordinary exhibition', Powerhouse can build a creative and innovative image.

Museums like MoMA have formulated innovative and useful approaches to leverage commonplace objects and made use of their brand power to provide platforms. The Museum of Modern Art (MoMA) has its own design store selling aesthetically and functionally excellent products (see **Figure 6**). This not only bridges the gap between the public and art, making art feel more accessible, but also creates platforms for brands and artists to feature their exceptional works in the museum store by capitalizing on MoMA's influence. Additionally, the Artist Residency Program at MoMA organizes artist residencies to support the creation of emerging artists with the help of mentors.

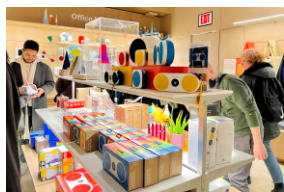


Figure 6. MoMA Store NYC

MoMA Design Store, shot by Eric on 18 December 2022. The stores offer MoMA's best selection of new and classic design objects and gifts.

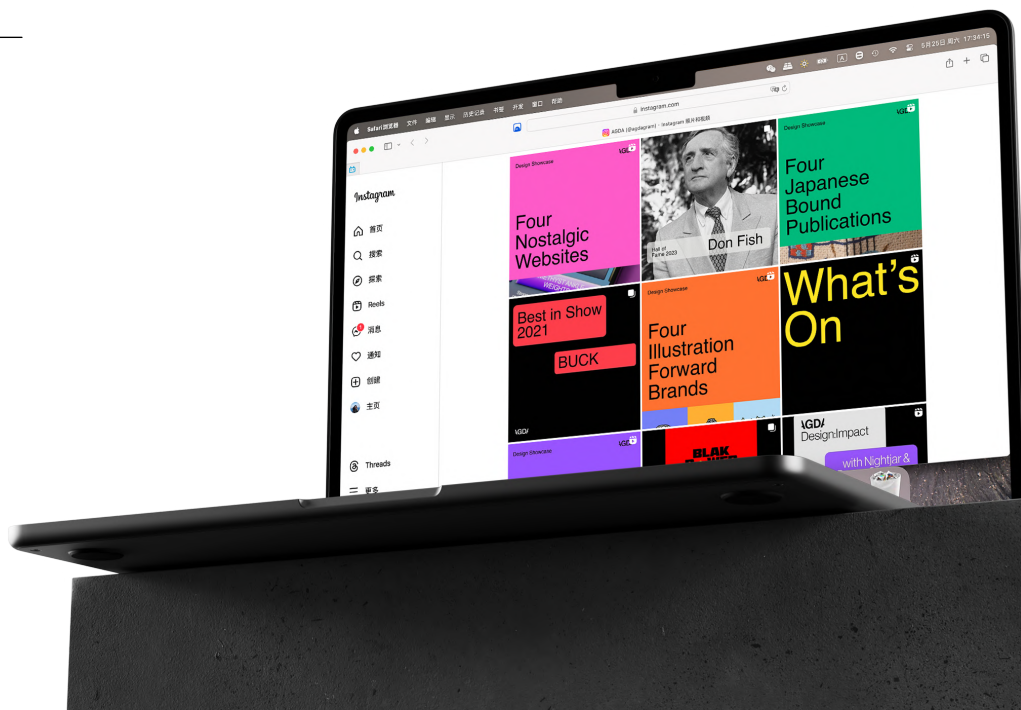


Figure 7. Powerhouse Museum offered its Research Fellowship Program 2023 only for PhD students.

These inspired my idea for the final outcome of our masterclass, where participating master students would have the opportunity to turn their outstanding 'ordinary' curation projects into real exhibitions at the Powerhouse Museum after taking masterclasses delivered by seasoned curators. Powerhouse then will be a platform for master students to spark interest and showcase talents, which can be seen as an extension of the Powerhouse Research Fellowship Program 2023 for PhD students (see **Figure 7**) and reach more students from broader fields (Powerhouse Museum, 2023).

In terms of media strategies, we will leverage Powerhouse Museum's resources and influence on Instagram and Facebook (I saw its Instagram ads many times). Additionally, we can take inspiration from the Australian Graphic Design Association (AGDA)'s use of their Instagram Design Curation series to showcase catalog works (see **Figure 8**) as a way to promote and build anticipation for our masterclass activities online.

Figure 8. AGDA's Design Curation series on Instagram



PART II. INSPIRATIONS

What were my sources of inspiration?

While conducting initial group discussions and my own secondary research, I utilized various creative and social platforms to find potential inspiration. My main sources of inspiration included the Powerhouse Museum's website and tour, Xiaohongshu (RED), and TOPYS.

INITIAL BIG IDEA: #UNWRAPIT

#UnwrapIt, the initial theme I proposed, was inspired while browsing posts on RED. I discovered a post about the artist Gelay Concepcion's project 'Things You Wanted To Say But Never Did' (see **Figure 9**) and used it as a springboard for idea development (Concepcion, 2024). The covered objects, the iconic element of this project, sparked my idea—perhaps the Powerhouse Museum could serve as the storyteller behind its collections, unwrapping the story. Thus, #UnwrapIt was born. I aimed to introduce the concept of unwrapping from a tangible perspective, starting with collections designed to be unwrapped, to a conceptual one that showcases how the Powerhouse Museum unwraps the concepts and stories behind its exhibits. This would also explain the techniques Powerhouse uses for 'unwrapping', thereby inspiring master students' interest in Powerhouse research.



Figure 9. Project 'Things You Wanted To Say But Never Did'

This project inspired me a lot. Although it is already conducted and spread on Instagram, we can use it as a springboard. For example, when creating a poster for our marketing campaign (if we have a similar concept like #WeUnwrapTheStory or #UnwrapIt) we can launch a series of posters that blur out parts of the exhibits on the poster while only revealing some of the clear parts, or fill in the shapes of the exhibits with text (but this idea was retained due to project adjustments).

INSPIRATION OF #ORDINARYMASTERCLASS

Through the Powerhouse website and tour, I further refined #UnwrapIt and developed a new approach #OrdinaryMasterclass. During our first discussion, we extended the topic from Philippe Starck's Juicy Salif juicer, which I chose for the blog, to other 'strange' objects. This led me to discover the Smartflush toilet by Caroma Industries on the website—a half-sectioned toilet that looked odd but interesting. I quickly created a mockup poster in class to showcase my idea (see **Figure 10**) and developed some media tactics, such as placing corresponding posters in unexpected locations to attract people's interest in this project. Additionally, as mentioned earlier, seeing the Nokia 5185i during the tour made me reflect on the significance of everyday items in a museum. These items carry not only historical and technological meaning, but also countless personal stories from collectors and visitors, providing emotional connections for everyone who engages with them (but the story needs to be unwrapped in some ways). This insight guided the specific content of our masterclass, emphasizing the instruction of storytelling and the ability to find the value behind ordinary objects.



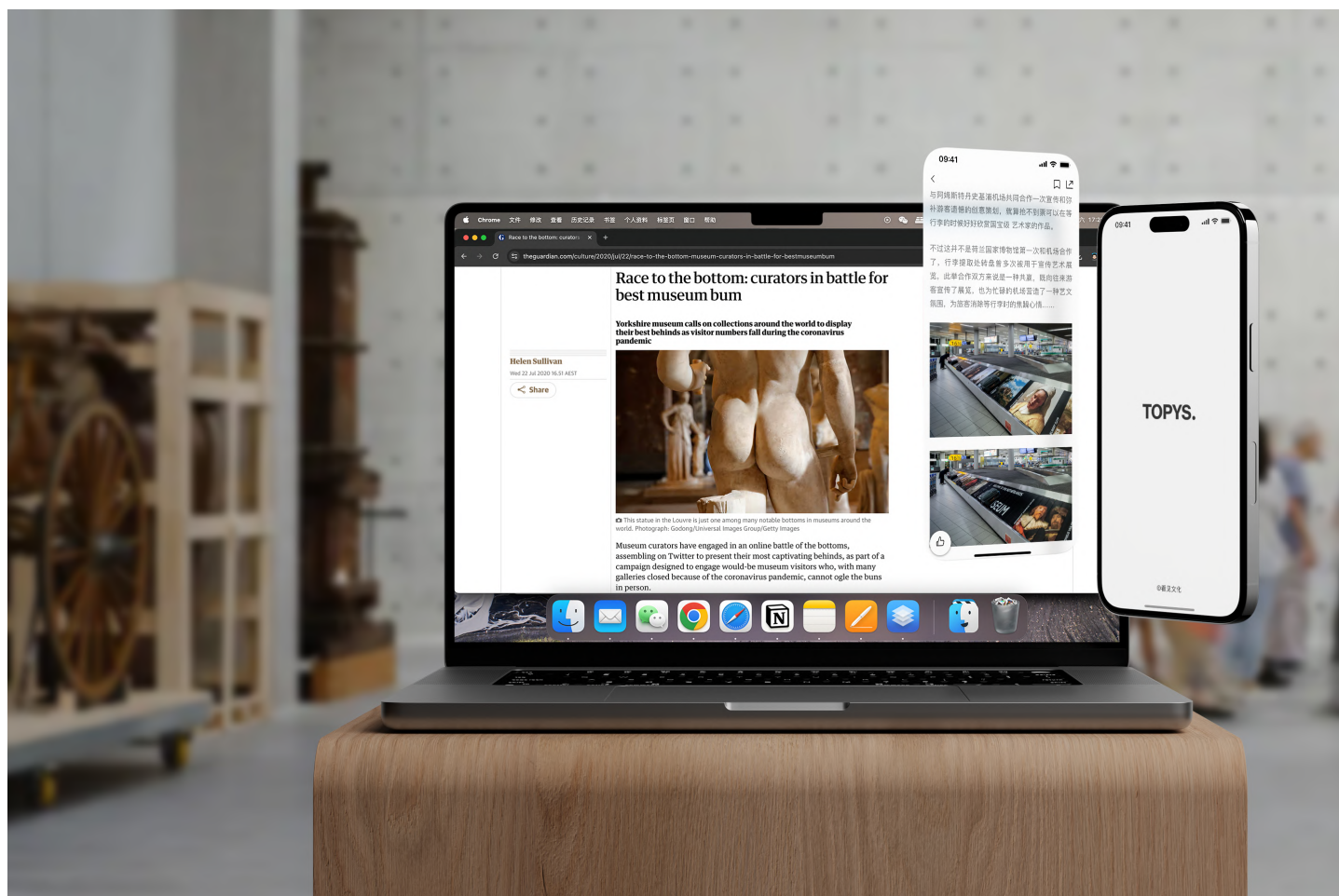
Figure 10. Poster Mockup

Select some sectioned objects from Powerhouse Collection to create a series of 'We unwrap this ____' posters and place them in front of the corresponding real items. This contrast will draw attention to our project. Background image source: (Libra, n.d.)

FURTHER EXPLORATION

Besides, to expand our activities and explore interesting events at other museums, I browsed campaign articles on TOPYS, a creative website run by a Chinese agency. Unfortunately, past creative cases on TOPYS did not provide me with much inspiration but rather validated the feasibility of my approaches. For example, the British Museum's #BestMuseumBum campaign demonstrated the appeal of using strange objects as a focal point (Sullivan, 2020). Similarly, the Rijksmuseum's exhibition at airport luggage carousels (see **Figure 11**), which brought the art closer to the public, parallels our activities of introducing storytelling and curation techniques to master students through the masterclass.

Figure 11. Articles on TOPYS and other inspirational events conducted by museums.



PART III. TEAMWORK AND MYSELF

What did I learn about teamwork, strategies, and myself?

TEAMWORK



Figure 12. Our first discussion

In terms of teamwork, this semester was my first time working with people from different countries, which brought many challenges beyond the coursework. Since English is not the first language for any of the four group members and I only started extensively using English for daily communication this semester (see **Figure 12**), I often struggled to clearly convey my ideas during group discussions, especially in the creative sector. Moreover, as Sally and I are both from China, we sometimes found ourselves switching to Chinese during brainstorming sessions to quickly and freely express our thoughts before compiling our ideas and discuss them with Anna and Andrew in the first two weeks. This reduced the productivity and breadth of creativity in our teamwork to some extent.

PRODUCTIVITY IMPROVEMENT

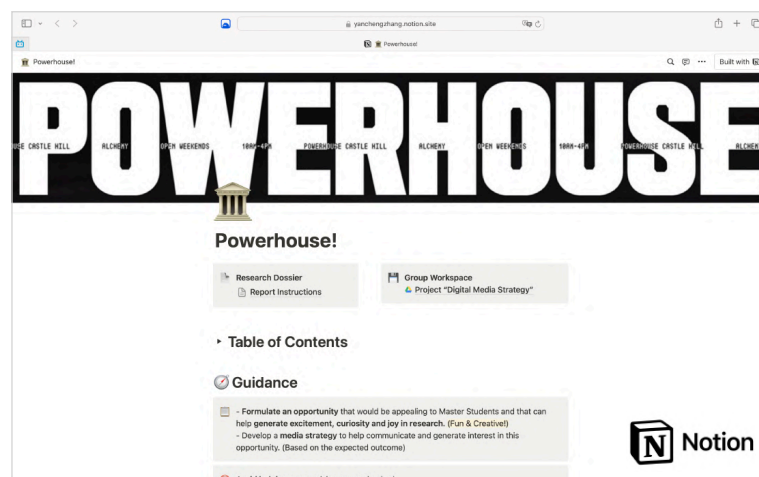
To address the productivity issue, I then summarized as many ideas as possible in writing, along with relevant links, before each class to efficiently share them during discussions (see **Figure 13**). For example, before finalizing the content and media strategies for our workshops, I reviewed the schemes that Powerhouse had previously implemented and its available technologies and media resources that we could utilize. Additionally, I wrote down potential project introductions for the video, outlined ideas for each workshop, and drafted potential content for the media strategies section.

SELF-ANALYSIS AND FUTURE PROJECTS

This group project also helped me reflect on my workflow and teamwork. I realized that I prefer to conduct multidimensional research in the early stages of a project, exploring information related to the client and target audience. This research not only provided a solid foundation for the creative process, but also inspired me and helped identify key entry points. In future group projects, I hope to improve my leadership and ability to communicate effectively and move a project forward.

Figure 13. Digital Project Dossier on Notion

I documented all relevant materials of this project on Notion. This document is **important for me** since it details my idea development process and thoughts, and compiles my research materials. You can access it via the following link or in **Appendix B** (only people who have this link can access): yanchengzhang.notion.site/Powerhouse-2de002e7fb584cf791b62f5e6a71f095



END OF REFLECTION

Please check the
appendixes on next page



1305 WORDS

Main text word count



APPENDIXES AND REFERENCES

start from the next page

APPENDIXES

A. MY PROJECT MOODBOARD

This moodboard contains the various ideas and sources of inspiration that were adopted or generated during the discussions. Every time I look at this board, my memories of the project are instantly revived.

You can access the embedded links in the PDF version from the digital dossier site below (Ideas and Inspirations section).

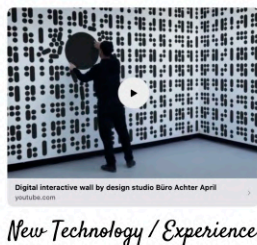
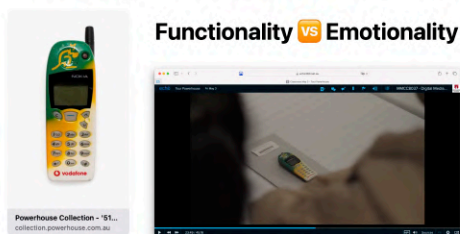
yanchengzhang.notion.site/Powerhouse-2de002e7fb584cf791b62f5e6a71f095

POWERHOUSE MASTERCLASS: HOW TO CURATE AN ORDINARY EXHIBITION

Goal & Vision?

**#NewForm of
Exhibition**

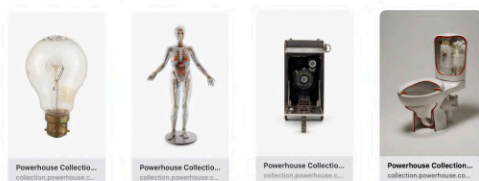
Storytelling
Story of Everyman #DailyOrdinary



POWERHOUSE

#UnwrapIt
#VisibleInvisibles?

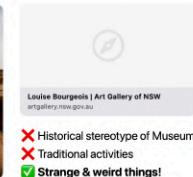
1. Powerhouse collects objects that are designed to appear **unwrapped**.
2. Powerhouse **unwraps** the concepts and stories behind exhibits.
3. Powerhouse Research team **unwraps** the essence, preservation methods, and deeper understanding of the exhibits through research and technology.



**#Escape
from Reality**

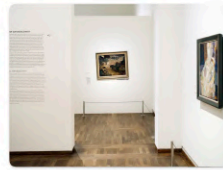
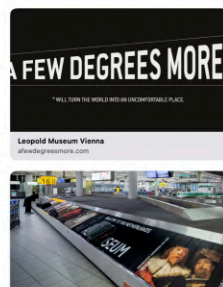


Master Students
Anxious in **future careers**
Escape from the reality in museum



**#DoNot
Touch**

**#Abnormal
Exhibition**



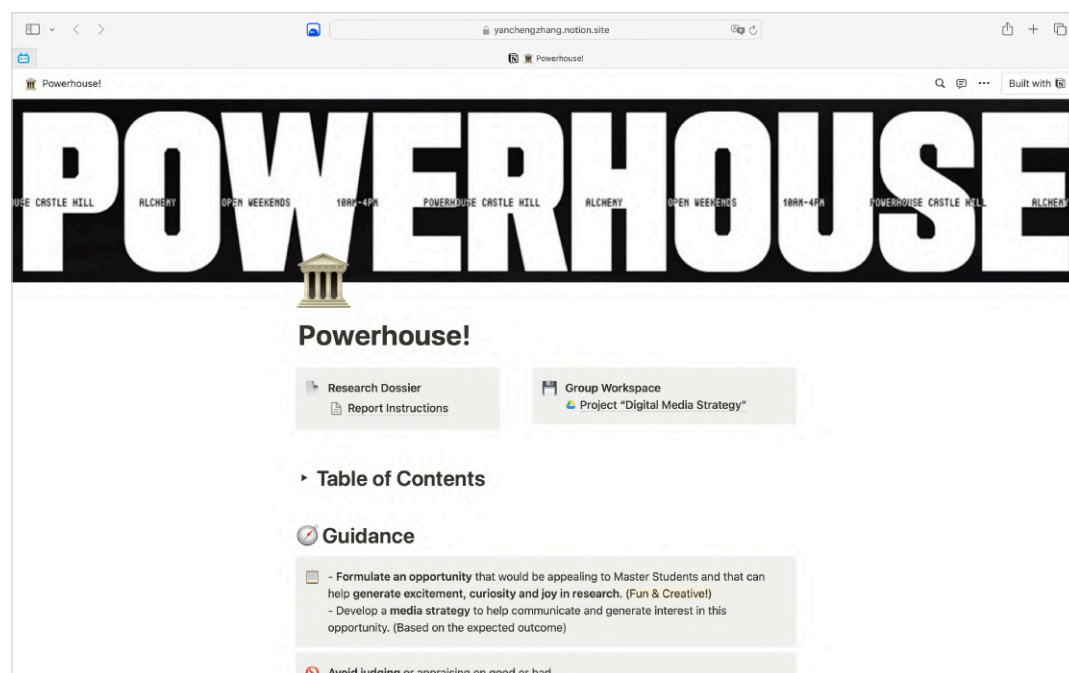
IT'S TIME FOR #CURATORBATTLE!
Today's theme is #BestMuseumBum!
This cracking Roman marble statuette depicts an athlete at the peak of fitness! It may have decorated the town house of one of Eboracum's wealthier residents. Has someone taken a bite out of this?



B. DIGITAL PERSONAL PROJECT DOSSER

This Notion dossier is my personal workspace of this project. I documented all relevant materials of this project. You are invited to access it via the private link below.

yanchengzhang.notion.site/Powerhouse-2de002e7fb584cf791b62f5e6a71f095



▼ Table of Contents

[Table of Contents](#)

[Guidance](#)

[Ideas and Inspirations](#)

[Powerhouse Masterclass: How to Curate an Ordinary Exhibition](#)

[#UnwrapIt](#)

[Functionality vs. Emotionality](#)

[Digital modeling x Storytelling](#)

[Attitude towards Arts](#)

[Campaign for Research: We unwrap the story.](#)

[MoMA Branding](#)

[2nd Research](#)

[About Powerhouse](#)

[Powerhouse Research Fellowship Program 2023](#)

[Vision and activities](#)

[Target Audience Insights](#)

[Information input](#)

[Visiting purpose and preferences](#)

[Methodology: online ethnography](#)

[Media Strategy Ideas](#)

[Teaser Campaign](#)

[Interactive Content](#)

[University Collaboration Events](#)

[Publication/Catalogue Giveaway](#)

[Design Guidelines](#)

[Ref.](#)

REFERENCES

- Concepcion, G. (2024, March 3). *Things You Wanted To Say But Never Did* [Post].
Instagram. https://www.instagram.com/p/C4B_zVgPqKk/?hl=en&img_index=3
- Libra. (n.d.). *Period Positivity Program*. Red Crayon. Retrieved on May 23, 2024, from
<https://redcrayon.com.au/portfolio/libra-period-positivity-program>
- MOD. (2017, September 27). *MOD. lesson #3: What young adults want from a museum experience*. <https://mod.org.au/2017/09/27/mod-lesson-3-young-adults-want-museum-experience/>
- Powerhouse Museum. (2023). *POWERHOUSE RESEARCH FELLOWSHIP PROGRAM 2023*. https://maas-website-media.s3.amazonaws.com/maas.museum/uploads/2022/10/220810_PH_Research_Fellowship_Program_2023-1.pdf
- Sullivan, H. (2020, July 22). *Race to the bottom: curators in battle for best museum bum*. The Guardian. <https://www.theguardian.com/culture/2020/jul/22/race-to-the-bottom-museum-curators-in-battle-for-bestmuseumbum>
- V&A South Kensington. (n.d.). *London Design Festival 2023*. V&A. Retrieved on May 22, 2024, from <https://www.vam.ac.uk/festival/2023/london-design-festival-2023>